A LITTLE HONG KONG. A LITTLE EVERY DAY.

Cantonese, one word at a time.

HKGong Cantonese Starter Reference

Core words, pronunciation and sentence patterns - together in one friendly reference.







211 ENTRIES / 10 TOPICS / 8 SENTENCE PATTERNS

Find your way

01 Time words
02 People and places
03 Negation and possession
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YOUR FIRST CANTONESE REFERENCE

Cantonese, one word at a time.

HKGong Cantonese Starter Reference

A practical reference for core Cantonese words, Jyutping, meanings, usage notes, particles, measure words, home vocabulary and sentence patterns.

How to read the tables

Word = Cantonese characters. Jyutping = pronunciation, with tone numbers 1-6. English = practical meaning. Use / note = spoken, written, formal, or pattern guidance.

Spoken	Natural in conversation. These are often the forms you hear in Hong Kong daily speech.
Written	More formal or closer to standard written Chinese. Useful for reading, signs, subtitles, and formal text.

Why it matters

Learn the sound, the written form and how each word works in a sentence. Use the patterns in this guide to connect the pieces.

A FIRST SENTENCE TO KEEP IN MIND

你好，我想學廣東話。

nei5 hou2, ngo5 soeng2 hok6 gwong2 dung1 waa2.

Hello, I want to learn Cantonese. Notice the pattern: greeting + I + want + learn + Cantonese. This reference is designed to help you see those parts clearly.

01 / VOCABULARY / 1 OF 2

Time Words

Use these to place a sentence in time. Spoken forms are often more natural in daily Hong Kong Cantonese.

尋日 cam4 jat6
yesterday
Spoken

昨天 zok3 tin1
yesterday
Written / formal

今日 gam1 jat6
today

聽日 ting1 jat6
tomorrow
Spoken

後日 hau6 jat6
the day after tomorrow

琴晚 kam4 maan5
last night
Spoken

早啲 zou2 di1
earlier

之前 zi1 cin4
before

而家 ji4 gaa1
now
Spoken

之後 zi1 hau6
after / later

稍後 saau2 hau6
later
Written / formal

遲啲 ci4 di1
later
Spoken

01 / VOCABULARY / 2 OF 2

Time Words

Use these to place a sentence in time. Spoken forms are often more natural in daily Hong Kong Cantonese.

下次 haa6 ci3
next time

上次 soeng6 ci3
last time

今次 gam1 ci3
this time

然後 jin4 hau6
then / afterwards
Written

星期 sing1 kei4
week

一日 jat1 jat6
one day

早上 zou2 soeng5
morning
Written

中午 zung1 ng5
noon

下晝 haa6 zau3
afternoon
Spoken

黃昏 wong4 fan1
dusk / evening

晚上 maan5 soeng5
evening / night
Written

嗰陣 go2 zan6
at that time / back then
Spoken

02 / VOCABULARY / 1 OF 2

People, Demonstratives, Places

These are the building blocks for saying who, what, and where.

我 ngo5
I / me

你 nei5
you

佢 keoi5
he / she / singular they
One person; 佢哋 = they (plural)

哋 dei6
plural marker
我哋 = we

位 wai2
polite classifier for people
Spoken classifier pronunciation

自己 zi6 gei2
oneself

呢個 ni1 go3
this one

嗰個 go2 go3
that one

呢啲 ni1 di1
these

嗰啲 go2 di1
those

呢度 ni1 dou6
here

嗰度 go2 dou6
there

02 / VOCABULARY / 2 OF 2

People, Demonstratives, Places

These are the building blocks for saying who, what, and where.

餐廳 caan1 teng1
restaurant

學校 hok6 haau6
school

街 gaai1
street

路 lou6
road

市場 si5 coeng4
market
Written; 街市 is common in speech

公司 gung1 si1
company / office

酒店 zau2 dim3
hotel

醫院 ji1 jyun2
hospital

藥房 joek6 fong2
pharmacy

洗手間 sai2 sau2 gaan1
restroom / toilet

商店 soeng1 dim3
shop / store
Written

03 / VOCABULARY

Negation, To Be, Possession

These small words appear everywhere. Learn them early and sentences become much easier to parse.

唔 m4
not
Main spoken negator

係 hai6
to be
Identity: 我係...

嘅 ge3
possessive / descriptive particle
我嘅 = my

有 jau5
have / there is

冇 mou5
not have / there is not

有去過 jau5 heoi3 gwo3
have been to / have gone before
Experience pattern



A little Hong Kong

04 / VOCABULARY

Modal Words and Helpers

These words tell you about ability, desire, obligation, possibility, and future meaning.

識 sik1
know how to / have the ability to

想 soeng2
want / would like / think

鍾意 zung1 ji3
like
Spoken

喜歡 hei2 fun1
like
Written

想要 soeng2 jiu3
want to have / want

必須 bit1 seoi1
must
Formal

要 jiu3
want / need / have to

應該 jing1 goi1
should

會 wui5
will / can / likely to

將會 zoeng1 wui5
will / going to
Written

可以 ho2 ji5
can / may

可能 ho2 nang4
maybe / possible

或者 waak6 ze2
or / perhaps

05 / VOCABULARY / 1 OF 2

Adverbs and Connectors

These words change the rhythm of a sentence: frequency, amount, sequence, and contrast.

常常 soeng4 soeng4
often

有時 jau5 si4
sometimes

從來都 cung4 loi4 dou1
all along / ever
With 唔 or 冇: never

成日 seng4 jat6
all the time
Spoken

經常 ging1 soeng4
frequently

以前 ji5 cin4
before / in the past

好多 hou2 do1
a lot / many

一啲 jat1 di1
a little / some

時時 si4 si4
always / often

好少 hou2 siu2
rarely / very little

咁 gam3
so / that much

仲 zung6
still / also

05 / VOCABULARY / 2 OF 2

Adverbs and Connectors

These words change the rhythm of a sentence: frequency, amount, sequence, and contrast.

已經 ji5 ging1
already

再 zoi3
again

多次 do1 ci3
many times

夠 gau3
enough

都 dou1
all / also / even

就 zau6
then / just / precisely

只有 zi2 jau5
only have / there is only

另外 ling6 ngoi6
in addition / another

反對 faan2 deoi3
oppose / be against
Verb

如果 jyu4 gwo2
if

但係 daan6 hai6
but
Spoken

所以 so2 ji5
so / therefore

06 / VOCABULARY / 1 OF 4

Core Verbs

Use these core verbs to describe actions, then connect them with the people, places and time words in this guide.

行 haang4
walk

去 heoi3
go

回 wui4
return
Written

食 sik6
eat

飲 jam2
drink

加 gaa1
add

聞 man4
smell

賣 maai6
sell

買 maai5
buy

笑 siu3
laugh

哭 huk1
cry
Written

喊 haam3
cry
Spoken

06 / VOCABULARY / 2 OF 4

Core Verbs

Use these core verbs to describe actions, then connect them with the people, places and time words in this guide.

用 jung6
use

做 zou6
do / make

見 gin3
see / meet

讀 duk6
read / study

寫 se2
write

知 zi1
know

講 gong2
speak / say

傾 king1
chat
Spoken

搭 daap3
take / ride
Transport

嚟 lei4
come
Spoken

打 daa2
hit / call / play
Meaning depends on object

坐 co5
sit / ride

06 / VOCABULARY / 3 OF 4

Core Verbs

Use these core verbs to describe actions, then connect them with the people, places and time words in this guide.

站 zaam6
stand
Written

搵 wan2
look for / find
Spoken

找 zaau2
find / look for
Written; also settle a bill/change in some contexts

住 zyu6
live / stay

試 si3
try

玩 waan2
play

記 gei3
remember
Often 記得 gei3 dak1 in speech

拉 laai1
pull

推 teoi1
push

睇 tai2
watch / see / read
Spoken

聽 teng1
listen / hear

收 sau1
receive / accept

06 / VOCABULARY / 4 OF 4

Core Verbs

Use these core verbs to describe actions, then connect them with the people, places and time words in this guide.

比 bei2
compare / than

畀 bei2
give / to
Common Cantonese character

俾 bei2
give / allow
Variant form

入 jap6
enter

離開 lei4 hoi1
leave

關 gwaan1
close

開 hoi1
open / turn on

明白 ming4 baak6
understand

停 ting4
stop

學 hok6
learn

錫 sek3
kiss / cherish
Spoken

熄 sik1
turn off / extinguish

07 / VOCABULARY / 1 OF 2

Home and Everyday Nouns

A practical set for describing rooms, furniture, and things around the home.

啲嘢 di1 je5
things / something
Spoken

嘢 je5
stuff / thing
Spoken

房間 fong4 gaan1
room

桌子 coek3 zi2
table
Written; 枱 toi2 is common in speech

椅子 ji2 zi2
chair
Written; 櫈 dang3 is common in speech

公寓 gung1 jyu6
apartment
Written

廚房 cyu4 fong2
kitchen

客廳 haak3 teng1
living room

睡房 seoi6 fong2
bedroom

臥室 ngo6 sat1
bedroom
Written

陽台 joeng4 toi4
balcony

浴室 juk6 sat1
bathroom

門 mun4
door

窗 coeng1
window

07 / VOCABULARY / 2 OF 2

Home and Everyday Nouns

A practical set for describing rooms, furniture, and things around the home.

梳化 so1 faa3
sofa
Loanword

冰箱 bing1 soeng1
refrigerator
Written; 雪櫃 syut3 gwai6 is common

爐頭 lou4 tau4
stove burner

微波爐 mei4 bo1 lou4
microwave

洗衣機 sai2 ji1 gei1
washing machine

乾衣機 gon1 ji1 gei1
dryer

書架 syu1 gaa3
bookshelf

櫃子 gwai6 zi2
cabinet

風扇 fung1 sin3
fan

燈 dang1
lamp / light

空調 hung1 tiu4
air conditioner
Written; 冷氣 laang5 hei3 is common

窗簾 coeng1 lim4
curtain

味 mei6
taste / smell / flavour

08 / VOCABULARY / 1 OF 2

Measure Words and Quantifiers

Cantonese uses classifiers between numbers and nouns. 個 is common, but specific nouns often prefer specific measure words.

個 go3
general classifier
Very common

每個 mui5 go3
every

杯 bui1
cup / glass

片 pin3
slice / piece

頂 deng2
for hats / things on the head

棵 fo1
for plants / trees

隻 zek3
for animals / one of a pair

架 gaa3
for vehicles / large machines

行 hong4
line / row

打 daa1
dozen

篇 pin1
article / written piece

碗 wun2
bowl

粒 nap1
small round object

08 / VOCABULARY / 2 OF 2

Measure Words and Quantifiers

Cantonese uses classifiers between numbers and nouns. 個 is common, but specific nouns often prefer specific measure words.

餐 caan1
meal

份 fan6
portion / copy / document

啲 di1
some / plural-like amount
Informal and very common

全部 cyun4 bou6
all

幾個 gei2 go3
a few / several

少數 siu2 sou3
few / minority

任何 jam6 ho4
any

好多 hou2 do1
many / a lot

各 gok3
each

無數 mou4 sou3
countless

其他 kei4 taa1
other

所有 so2 jau5
all / every

左右 zo2 jau6
about / approximately

09 / VOCABULARY

Question Words

Many Cantonese question words stay in the place where the answer would appear.

邊個 bin1 go3
who

邊度 bin1 dou6
where

點解 dim2 gaai2
why

幾時 gei2 si4
when

點 dim2
how

邊 bin1
which

幾多 gei2 do1
how many / how much

做乜 zou6 mat1
why / what are you doing
Colloquial

乜 mat1
what



A little Hong Kong

10 / VOCABULARY

Final Particles and Aspect Markers

Sentence-final particles add attitude or emphasis. Aspect markers show how an action unfolds. Learn them in context.

呀 aa3
softens a statement or question
Sentence-final particle

吖 aa1
softens a request or suggestion
Meaning depends on context

喇 laa3
new situation / change of state
Often conveys now / already

啦 laa1
let's / please / urging
Compare 喇 laa3 for a change of state

架 gaa3
informal spelling of 嗰
Use 嗰 for this sentence ending

嗰 gaa3
assertion / explanation
Often analysed as 嘅 + 呀 (ge3 + aa3)

嘞 laak3
completion / change

咗 zo2
completed action
Aspect marker

緊 gan2
ongoing action
Aspect marker

過 gwo3
past experience
Aspect marker

住 zyu6
continuing state
Aspect marker

PUT THE PARTS TOGETHER

Mini Sentence Patterns

Use these patterns as simple anchors while you study the vocabulary above.

Subject + 唔 + Verb

我唔識。
ngo5 m4 sik1.
I do not know how.

Subject + 想 + Verb

我想學。
ngo5 soeng2 hok6.
I want to learn.

Subject + 係 + Noun

佢係老師。
keoi5 hai6 lou5 si1.
He or she is a teacher.

Subject + 喺 + Place

我喺睡房。
ngo5 hai2 seoi6 fong2.
I am in the bedroom.

Verb + 咗

我食咗。
ngo5 sik6 zo2.
I ate / I have eaten.

Verb + 緊

我學緊。
ngo5 hok6 gan2.
I am learning.

有 + Noun

呢度有餐廳。
ni1 dou6 jau5 caan1 teng1.
There is a restaurant here.

Question word in place

你去邊度？
nei5 heoi3 bin1 dou6?
Where are you going?

Keep learning with HKGong

Keep this guide nearby as you explore sounds, words and sentence patterns in HKGong. Choose one useful word or sentence and practise a little every day.

Download HKGong: https://hkgong.com